

Better Sleep: A Complete Hygiene Guide

Evidence-Based Strategies for Restorative Rest

Sleep is foundational to mental and physical health. Poor sleep worsens anxiety, depression, cognitive performance, and immune function.

Why Sleep Matters

Adults need	7-9 hours of sleep per night (WHO recommendation)
Sleep deprivation	Impairs cognition equivalent to being legally drunk after 17+ hrs awake
REM sleep	Critical for emotional regulation and memory consolidation
Chronic poor sleep	Linked to depression, anxiety, obesity, and heart disease
Good news	Sleep quality can improve significantly within 2-4 weeks of consistent practice

The Sleep Hygiene Checklist

Environment

- Keep bedroom cool (16-19 C / 61-66 F is optimal)
- Make your room as dark as possible — use blackout curtains or an eye mask
- Reduce noise — use earplugs or a white noise machine
- Reserve your bed only for sleep and intimacy, not work or TV
- Invest in a comfortable mattress and pillow

Schedule and Routine

- Go to bed and wake up at the same time every day, including weekends
- Avoid naps longer than 20 minutes, and not after 3 PM
- Get bright natural light in the morning (10-30 min)
- Create a 30-60 minute wind-down routine before bed
- Avoid vigorous exercise within 2 hours of bedtime

Food, Drink and Substances

- Avoid caffeine after 2 PM (coffee, tea, cola, energy drinks)
- Limit alcohol — it disrupts REM sleep even if it helps you fall asleep
- Avoid heavy meals within 3 hours of bedtime
- Stay hydrated during the day but reduce fluids 1-2 hours before bed

Mind and Technology

- Stop using screens at least 1 hour before bed
- Write a to-do list for tomorrow to offload worry from your mind
- Practise a relaxation technique: progressive muscle relaxation or box breathing
- If you cannot sleep after 20 minutes, get up and do something calm until sleepy
- Avoid checking the clock when you wake at night

The 2-Week Sleep Reset Plan

Days 1-3	Fix your wake time. Get up at the same time regardless of when you fell asleep.
Days 4-6	Add the wind-down routine: dim lights, stop screens, calming activity.
Days 7-9	Optimise your environment: temperature, darkness, noise.
Days 10-12	Audit food and drink. Remove afternoon caffeine and assess alcohol.
Days 13-14	Review and adjust. Track sleep quality and identify what works best.

My Sleep Diary (1 Week)

Day	Bed Time	Wake Time	Times Woke	Total Sleep	Quality (1-10)	Notes
Mon						
Tue						
Wed						
Thu						
Fri						
Sat						
Sun						